

Writing and Thinking with LLMs: Discipline Over Convenience

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Lecture 2

Writing Is a Commodity, Thinking Is Not

Writing tasks are now easy to automate, but thinking remains scarce.

- ▶ Large language models can generate essays, summaries, and reports on demand.
- ▶ The barrier to producing polished text has effectively disappeared.
- ▶ Superficial fluency is no longer a meaningful indicator of skill.
- ▶ Audiences are increasingly familiar with AI-generated patterns.
- ▶ Low-quality outputs are recognizable despite surface polish.
- ▶ Differentiation has shifted from producing text to producing insight.

The Collapse of Naive Writing Tasks

Traditional writing tasks no longer reliably measure competence.

- ▶ One-page essays, memos, and summaries can be generated instantly.
- ▶ Standard corporate formats are easily replicated by LLMs.
- ▶ These outputs have become commoditized across organizations.
- ▶ Readers can detect generic or formulaic AI-generated content.
- ▶ The presence of text no longer implies understanding or effort.
- ▶ Evaluation shifts from whether it was written to whether it is meaningful.

The Corporate Reality of Communication

Effective writing in professional contexts depends on clarity and credibility.

- ▶ Most stakeholders do not read long documents in detail.
- ▶ Careful readers evaluate quality immediately.
- ▶ Generic or verbose content undermines credibility.
- ▶ AI-generated patterns are increasingly recognizable in business settings.
- ▶ Influence depends on clarity of thought rather than quantity of text.
- ▶ Writing must support real-time communication and decision-making.

The New Role of the Human

The human role shifts from generating text to directing and evaluating it.

- ▶ Humans must define the problem and interpret results.
- ▶ Real-time thinking remains essential in meetings and presentations.
- ▶ Arguments must be formed independently of the tool.
- ▶ LLMs cannot replace dynamic, context-sensitive responses.
- ▶ The user is responsible for coherence and correctness.
- ▶ The tool amplifies capability but does not replace judgment.

Analogy: Thinking Without Assistance

Human cognition must remain functional without constant tool support.

- ▶ Tools assist but are not always available in real-time situations.
- ▶ Presentations and discussions require immediate reasoning.
- ▶ Internal competence enables effective use of external tools.
- ▶ Reliance without understanding leads to failure under pressure.
- ▶ Mastery requires both tool use and independent capability.
- ▶ The tool is an extension rather than a substitute for cognition.

Grounded Writing: Start with Sources

Effective writing begins with grounding in real information.

- ▶ Conduct a literature or document search relevant to the topic.
- ▶ Review abstracts and summaries to assess relevance.
- ▶ Select high-quality academic, industry, or news sources.
- ▶ Avoid beginning with open-ended prompts to the model.
- ▶ Use external information to constrain the model's output.
- ▶ Establish factual grounding before generating text.

Grounded Writing: Input Real Content

The model should operate on real documents rather than free-form prompts.

- ▶ Provide PDFs, articles, or curated text as input.
- ▶ Extract key elements such as titles, authors, and sections.
- ▶ Request structured summaries of each source.
- ▶ Ensure the model operates within provided material.
- ▶ Reduce reliance on the model's internal distribution.
- ▶ Treat the model as a processor of information, not a source.

Grounded Writing: Build Structure

Structured summaries create a stable foundation for writing.

- ▶ Compile an annotated bibliography from selected sources.
- ▶ Generate concise summaries for each reference.
- ▶ Maintain consistent citation formats.
- ▶ Use structured outputs to organize information.
- ▶ Create reusable reference sets for future work.
- ▶ Build a foundation before drafting content.

Controlling the Model: Explicit Instruction

Clear instruction is required to constrain model behavior.

- ▶ Instruct the model to avoid meta text and unnecessary commentary.
- ▶ Specify stylistic constraints such as tone and voice.
- ▶ Prohibit unwanted formatting unless explicitly needed.
- ▶ Define structure and output expectations clearly.
- ▶ Reinforce constraints repeatedly when necessary.
- ▶ Treat instruction as an ongoing process.

Controlling the Model: Active Correction

Users must intervene actively to maintain correctness and relevance.

- ▶ Identify and call out hallucinations immediately.
- ▶ Reject outputs that deviate from the task.
- ▶ Reinforce boundaries when the model drifts.
- ▶ Do not accept partially correct responses.
- ▶ Guide the model back to the intended objective.
- ▶ Maintain control over the conversation direction.

Controlling the Model: Multiple Conversations

Separating tasks into distinct contexts improves reliability.

- ▶ Use one conversation for content generation.
- ▶ Use another for editing and critique.
- ▶ Assign distinct roles to each interaction.
- ▶ Prevent context contamination between tasks.
- ▶ Maintain focused and manageable interactions.
- ▶ Treat conversations as components of a workflow.

Question-Driven Writing Method

Writing improves when used to structure thinking rather than replace it.

- ▶ Define the topic and provide relevant sources.
- ▶ Ask the model to generate structured questions.
- ▶ Use these questions to guide your thinking.
- ▶ Answer each question independently.
- ▶ Build content from your own responses.
- ▶ Ensure ideas originate from the human.

Incremental Drafting

Documents should be built in controlled sections rather than generated at once.

- ▶ Draft one section at a time.
- ▶ Provide context and constraints for each section.
- ▶ Avoid generating full documents in a single prompt.
- ▶ Maintain control over structure and progression.
- ▶ Reduce drift and inconsistency.
- ▶ Assemble sections into a coherent whole.

Iterative Refinement: Improving Quality

High-quality writing emerges through repeated evaluation and revision.

- ▶ Remove redundant content across sections.
- ▶ Ensure consistent tone and voice.
- ▶ Eliminate generic or formulaic phrasing.
- ▶ Improve clarity and precision of language.
- ▶ Review transitions between sections.
- ▶ Perform multiple refinement passes.

Iterative Refinement: Multi-Model Review

Using multiple models can improve detection of weaknesses.

- ▶ Use a second model for critique and analysis.
- ▶ Identify patterns typical of AI-generated text.
- ▶ Focus on sentence-level improvements.
- ▶ Detect verbosity and repetition.
- ▶ Apply targeted refinements.
- ▶ Combine strengths of different systems.

Ethical Boundary: Ownership and Attribution

LLM use introduces questions about authorship and responsibility.

- ▶ Fully generated content presented as original is plagiarism.
- ▶ Editing self-authored content is acceptable.
- ▶ Intermediate cases require careful judgment.
- ▶ Ownership depends on origin of ideas.
- ▶ Proper citation may be necessary.
- ▶ Ethical use requires transparency.

Discussion

Writing with LLMs requires discipline and structured control.

- ▶ LLMs are powerful but unreliable without constraints.
- ▶ Quality depends on grounding in real information.
- ▶ Structure and workflow determine reliability.
- ▶ Human oversight is required at every stage.
- ▶ Effective use depends on discipline, not convenience.
- ▶ Advantage comes from directing and constraining the tool.

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